

C16 B AFFORDABLE HOUSING | O (MAX : 2 PT)

Intent : Promote housing equity through the allocation of healthy affordable housing units.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects to designate affordable housing units that are tenure blind, reduce housing costs for low-income tenants and offer multi-bedroom options.

Issue : Families unable to find affordable housing spend a significant share of their income on housing costs, leaving insufficient resources to cover other basic needs such as food, clothing, utilities and medical care.¹⁻³ Across the United States, European Union, Japan and Australia, over 60 million households are financially stretched by housing costs. ⁴ With lack of affordable housing access, an estimated 235 million urban families live in substandard housing, which exposes them to mold, dust, water leaks, lead-based paint, poor air quality, temperature extremes and vermin, leading to poor health outcomes like asthma, infectious disease, cardiovascular events and children's nervous system damage.^{1-3,5,6} In 2016, only 3.2 million affordable housing units were available for the 10.4 million extremely low-income households in the United States; in India, there is a deficit of 11 million affordable units.^{7,8} In rural England, only 8% of housing stock is affordable compared to 20% in urban areas.⁹ Affordable housing shortages lead to homelessness, which increases stress, substance use and morbidity in adults and mental health issues and depression in youth.^{3,6,10}

Solutions : Increasing housing affordability, quality and safety improves resident health, feelings of security and self-esteem, and increases developmental ability and nutrition levels in children.^{3,6} Affordable housing access can help prevent communicable diseases, improve overall health and provide a stable and efficient platform for the delivery of food, healthcare and essential services, especially for vulnerable groups such as the elderly, children, and individuals with chronic illnesses or disabilities.^{1,3,5,6,10} With rising urbanization, healthy affordable housing will be critical for community health promotion.

PART 1 ALLOCATE AFFORDABLE HOUSING (MAX : 2 PT)

For Dwelling Units:

The project meets the following requirements:

- a. A percentage of dwelling units are allocated for tenants whose incomes are at or below an income limit relative to the local median household income [e.g., Area Median Income (AMI)] and adjusted for family size. Recognition is awarded as per the selected tier in the table below:

Tier	Units Allocated and Income Limited	Point Value
1	20% of units or more, 0 - 50% of local median OR 40% of units or more, 51 - 80% of local median	1 point
2	100% of units, 0 - 80% of local median	2 points

- b. Total annual housing costs (i.e., rent and utilities) paid by affordable unit tenants are less than 30% of the income limit selected in requirement (a).
- c. Housing costs are maintained at the levels described in this feature for the duration of a project's engagement with WELL.
- d. Affordable housing units are not visually or functionally distinctive from market-rate units (if present) and have the same access point into the building.
- e. In projects with 10 or more affordable housing units, at least 50% of allocated units have two or more bedrooms and at least 10% of allocated units have three or more bedrooms.

Note : This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

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